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Colombian Paramilitaries Since Demobilization: Between State Crackdown and Increased Violence

Krzysztof Krakowski

ABSTRACT

This article addresses the puzzle of heterogeneous trends in paramilitary violence on the Colombian Pacific Coast since the beginning of the disarmament, demobilization, and reintegration (DDR) process in 2003. The usual explanations derived from political conflict theories are improved with insights from organized crime research. The article argues that the occasional escalation of post-DDR paramilitary violence at the subregional level cannot be explained by the weakness of the state argument. Instead, the article demonstrates the counterintuitive evidence that paramilitary violence correlates positively with the incidence of state repressive intervention against paramilitary groups. More specifically, paramilitaries challenged by the state use more violence, either to replace their nonviolent resources most affected by law enforcement activities or to respond to crackdown-related intensification of predatory tendencies within their respective organizations.

At the beginning of the twenty-first century, Colombia was one of the most insecure places in the world. Violence perpetrated by civil conflict participants reached its highest levels since the outbreak of the full-fledged civil war in 1978. In 2003 the trend of an almost uninterrupted 15-year rise in conflict-related homicides finally reversed, and between 2003 and 2009, conflict-related homicides decreased nearly by half (Granada, Restrepo, and Vargas 2009, 73). This security improvement was widely attributed to a conflict resolution scheme designed by Colombian president Álvaro Uribe, who offered the opportunity of voluntary disarmament, demobilization, and reintegration (DDR) to all participants in the conflict.

The most notable success of this scheme came from the collective demobilization of the paramilitary union, Autodefensas Unidas de Colombia (AUC), which, by the end of 2006, resulted in the disarmament of more than 31,000 paramilitary soldiers (Restrepo and Muggah 2009, 36). Despite the almost immediate re-emergence of some paramilitary groups, Restrepo, and Muggah (2009) find quantitative evidence that the application of the DDR program contributed to considerable security improvements, since it helped to reduce the amount of paramilitary violence perpetrated in the country (so-called deparamilitarization of the conflict).¹

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However, the authors admit that there are some areas where DDR application did not bring expected security dividends (Restrepo and Muggah 2009, 43). The occasional nonimprovement of postdemobilization security is the empirical puzzle this article addresses. To put it another way, the article will try to answer the question of why some subregions benefited from DDR-related “deparamilitarization” of conflict more than others.

Restrepo and Muggah (2009, 43) speculate that occasional DDR failure to improve regional security could be related to “the absence of adequate state presence ... the continuation of the conflict and the emergence of new groups.” Howe et al. (2010) tested this hypothesis quantitatively and confirmed that the biggest DDR-related security improvements (reductions in homicide rates) occurred in the municipalities with the best policing (measured as arrests per homicides). In short, the study found that DDR failure can be explained by the argument of state weakness (limited central government authority over Colombian territory).

There are a few problems with Howe et al.’s findings, though. First, the authors use the proxy of policing quality (arrests per homicides) at department level to explain municipal homicide rates (2010, 22). It is entirely possible that in some departments, law enforcement activities were concentrated only in a few municipal areas (see Sánchez et al. 2011), and therefore the department-level measurement of policing may obscure within-department variability. Since the homicide rates are heterogeneous within departments, we could hardly exclude the possibility of a spurious finding. More important, if post-DDR security improved with the “deparamilitarization” of the conflict, Howe et al. might have omitted an important variable by not controlling for state antiparamilitary offensive actions that are not reflected in police operational statistics. To the best of my knowledge, it was not the police but the military forces that challenged Colombian paramilitaries most seriously after 2003. Failing to account for military repression along with conventional measures of policing may lead to an overestimation of the actual “weakness” of the state.

For these reasons, I find it worthwhile to reexamine the determinants of heterogeneous DDR outcomes since the beginning of Uribe’s peace process in 2003. According to all existing DDR evaluations, the reduction of paramilitary violence constituted the crucial mechanism of bringing security improvements to the Colombian regions, and I believe that in order to understand the heterogeneity of DDR achievements one needs to analyze the dynamics of paramilitary violence.

This article analyzes paramilitary violence trends on the Colombian Pacific Coast for the period 2003–2009. It will demonstrate that, contrary to explanations that stress state weakness as a root cause of DDR failure, occasional security nonimprovements can be explained with reference to the determined state intervention against paramilitary groups. To put it another way, the article will show that a recent escalation of violent paramilitary crimes in some Pacific Coast subregions can actually be linked to improved law enforcement and continuous antiparamilitary crack-down. The argument follows an observation that law enforcement activities may have both positive and negative effects on insecurity. It is a well-established criminological fact that law enforcement activities deter crimes (Cook 2008), but this

relationship does not hold for all types of crime (Friedman 1995). Smith and Varese (2001) argue, for example, that improved policing does actually increase violent crimes perpetrated by organized crime groups and other types of extralegal governance providers (paramilitaries included).

The article is organized as follows. First it discusses the conceptual approach to investigating the relationship between state repressive actions (law enforcement anti-paramilitary crackdown) and organized crime violence. It formulates one general proposition about this relationship and two hypotheses that explain the mechanisms linking state repression to paramilitary violence. Second, it presents an original dataset and research design based on the analysis of regional heterogeneity of paramilitary violence trends on the Colombian Pacific Coast from 2003 to 2009. It develops statistical models to account for the observed violence dynamics, and then uses qualitative data to demonstrate the plausibility of hypothesized mechanisms that link state repression to paramilitary violence. The article concludes with some policy implications.

CONCEPTUAL APPROACH

We know little about the logic of paramilitary violence beyond its counterinsurgency aspect (Romero 2003; Medina Gallego 1990; Arjona and Kalyvas 2005). There are a few studies that link the amount of violence perpetrated by Colombian paramilitary groups to their organizational structure, but given the lack of systematic data, these works usually do not go beyond straightforward claims about the association between groups' fragmentation (the quality of leadership) and intragroup violence (Garzón 2008, 47–48; Rozema 2008, 448–52).

Probably one of the most overlooked and underresearched aspects of paramilitary violence is its relationship with law enforcement repressive actions. This important gap may stem from the fact that paramilitary groups are widely known for their nonbelligerent relations with the state (Arjona and Kalyvas 2005, 28–29), which was certainly the case in Colombia at least until the early twenty-first century (Áviles 2006). Academic studies of state repression and its impact on organized violence usually model the relationship between government repression and dissident movements with an underlying assumption of competitors' distance on policy preferences (Moore 2000; Carey 2006; Ritter 2014). In the case at hand, however, there is evidence of historical similarity in policy preferences between paramilitaries and the Colombian state (see Áviles 2006). It makes the existing models informative for the research design of this study but not straightforwardly applicable to the forthcoming analyses. All things considered, I believe that in order to understand the relationship between state repression and paramilitary violence one needs to refer to the logic of organized crime violence, rather than a political one.

What makes Colombian paramilitaries similar to organized crime actors is their involvement in extralegal governance (Arjona and Kalyvas 2005, 29). Colombia has a long tradition of extralegal governance; its key providers range from political rebels to all sorts of self-defense units (indigenous guards and armed wings of criminal syndicates included; see Medina Gallego 1990; Henderson 2001; Barreto Henriques

2009). The omnipresence of private ordering in the country is often explained as a result of geographically fragmented territory and a still-not-consolidated national identity, which prevents the establishment of strong central authorities (Thoumi 2012, 984).

In this picture, contemporary paramilitaries represent one of the most complex forms of private ordering. Their history begins in the 1980s, when the Medellín drug cartel urgently needed an armylike structure to protect its interests from guerrilla advances. At that time, insurgent organizations (fighting against the Colombian state since the mid-1960s) discovered the booming drug economy as a perfect way to finance their war efforts. They posed a serious threat to traditional drug traffickers, who responded by creating their own paramilitary units (Medina Gallego 1990). Newborn paramilitaries rapidly spread across Colombian territory, thanks to their counterinsurgency orientation and favorable legislation that permitted anyone to create a personal self-defense group as a means of protection from all sorts of political rebels (Áviles 2006, 385).

The expanding paramilitarism took over most of the smaller organized crime groups, to the point of dominating even the big drug cartels (Duncan 2005; Camacho and López 2007). Since their very beginning, paramilitaries offered protection services to legal enterprises run by land-rich classes, such as cattle ranchers, commercial agriculture workers, and emerald barons—all threatened by guerrillas' expanding territorial control (Medina Gallego 1990).

All this evidence shows that throughout their contemporary history, Colombian paramilitaries regularly have dealt with the provision of private security and have been continuously involved in various forms of extralegal governance. Varese (2010) argues that such groups can be incorporated into criminal research and described with the same analytical categories as gangs, organized crime groups, and mafias—each of them placed on various points of the same extralegal governance continuum.

A fundamental characteristic of extralegal governance is its monopolistic character. It is a zero-sum game in which only the winner effectively establishes his authority (Nozick 1974, chap. 1). In order to monopolize private ordering markets, extralegal governance providers (paramilitaries included) require very specific resources, such as intelligence, violence, reputation, and advertising (Gambetta 1992, chap. 2). Reuter (1995) and Rankin (2012) show that a state anti-organized crime crackdown can affect all of these resources, but it is more successful in damaging some of them (intelligence, reputation, and advertising) than others (violence). Gambetta (1992, 40–46) argues that there is an inversely proportional relationship between criminal resources (e.g., between reputation and violence), which implies that they are all substitutable. As a result, extralegal governance providers can make up for the loss of most crackdown-affected resources by replacing them with those affected to a lesser degree.

To illustrate the point, Smith and Varese (2001) describe the case of an extortion racket that suffers from the loss of its local authority as a result of improved policing in the area. The authors explain that racketeers in well-policed environ-

ments tend to intensify their use of violence because their victims feel safer with all the police around and start to “test” the credibility of racketeers’ threats by increasingly refusing to pay extortion money. What the racketeers have to do to reestablish their local authority in similar situations is to punish violently all “uncooperative” victims. Thanks to such exemplary punishments, other would-be victims realize the high costs of disobedience and more easily yield to extortionists’ future demands (Smith and Varese 2001). In short, the example shows that violence appears to be a handy fix for reputation deficit in private ordering markets.

State repression provokes violence among extralegal governance providers not only because it affects their resources. Sánchez-Jankowski (1991) claims, for instance, that gangs increase their use of violence as a result of fear. Varese (2014) elaborates the argument by showing that fear-driven violence may reflect the situation when criminals turn to practices of illicit wealth accumulation, which require high volumes of coercion but bring large rewards in the short run (e.g., predation). The short-run profitable predation seems to be a preferable option for criminals facing a determined state crackdown with a high probability of their immediate imprisonment and low expectations to stay in business for a long time—all of which gives them a disincentive to switch from “roving” to “stationary” banditry (Olson 1993). The preference for “roving” banditry prevails also among the underpaid rank and file and midlevel criminal leaders, for whom fighting creates an opportunity to climb the criminal hierarchy (Levitt and Venkatesh 2000).

There are reasons to believe that a state crackdown reinforces these preferences at the organization level by pushing criminal groups toward some organizational adaptations that, on the one hand, help them to avoid excessive exposure to law enforcement authorities, but at the same time reduce centralized control over predatory tendencies. These adaptations include organizational horizontality and outsourcing (Blok 2008, 18) and the limitation of extralegal governance services to the less visible markets of illicit commodities (Shortland and Varese 2014, 743). Decentralized organized crime structures with scarce interest in socioeconomic exchange intensify their use of violence because they face a dilemma of decentralized predation: every predator maximizes the volume of his loot because he knows that whatever is left behind will undoubtedly fall prey to his fellow predators (Easterly 2006, 309). Decentralization of this kind makes it difficult to coordinate the activities of various criminal factions, which often enter into violent competition among themselves.

Coming back to the Colombian case, there is no doubt that the state antiparamilitary repression provoked resource and fear shocks among local paramilitary groups on the Pacific Coast (see Sánchez et al. 2011). To understand the significance of these crackdown-related shocks, we need to consider that until 2000, Colombian paramilitaries were almost never challenged by public forces (Granada and Sánchez 2009, 262). Some researchers even claim that paramilitaries’ relatively stable governance never would have been possible if not for the tolerance of the public authorities (Medina Gallego 1990; Romero 2003; Áviles 2006). Given the tradition of good relations with the Colombian state, it seems reasonable to expect that a rapid increase in state military pressure must have had far-reaching conse-

quences for paramilitaries' organization and resources, altering the previously established equilibrium.

All theoretical arguments considered, we can formulate one general proposition about the relationship between state repression and paramilitary violence, as well as two specific hypotheses that identify the exact mechanisms driving the relationship.

Proposition: State repressive intervention increased paramilitary violence on the Colombian Pacific Coast after the beginning of the DDR program.

H1. State repression affected such paramilitary resources as reputation, advertising, and intelligence, which were replaced with violence (a less crackdown-affected resource).

H2. Increased risks associated with state repression intensified paramilitaries' predatory tendencies and led to violent conflicts among the individual groups.

One caveat needs to be stated. I do not claim that state repression is the only factor responsible for intensifying paramilitary violence, yet I believe it remains the most counterintuitive and least understood one, and that is why it requires more detailed theoretical explanation in the present section. Other factors already found to be correlated with organized violence in general or paramilitary violence specifically will be discussed in the empirical section, where all the variables to be included in the regression analyses are described.

RESEARCH DESIGN AND DATA

As stated earlier, the aim of this article is to reconstruct the logic of paramilitary violence in the context of a partial peace process (2003–6) marked by the successful disarmament of nearly 40,000 irregular combatants, including more than 31,000 collectively demobilized paramilitary soldiers (Restrepo and Muggah 2009, 36). This DDR initiative was characterized by some stark peculiarities, and therefore it seemed to be designed to cool down the ongoing conflict rather than to effectively terminate it. To begin with, pro-state paramilitary groups largely outnumbered anti-state insurgents as the main beneficiaries of the DDR program. Moreover, the program did not extend to all paramilitary factions. While some of them refused to participate, a few important groups that wanted to disarm within the scheme were denied this opportunity on the basis of very controversial and highly arbitrary criteria (Duncan 2005).

In the end, the DDR process left enormous space for peace “spoilers” among both the insurgents and the paramilitaries. Because of this unusual context, the peace process paradoxically was accompanied by the state's heavy military crackdown on all conflict participants (Granada, Restrepo, and Vargas 2009). I believe that it was this very intervention that canceled DDR-related security dividends in some parts of the country. Before this claim is verified empirically, the data and comparative design will be discussed in detail.

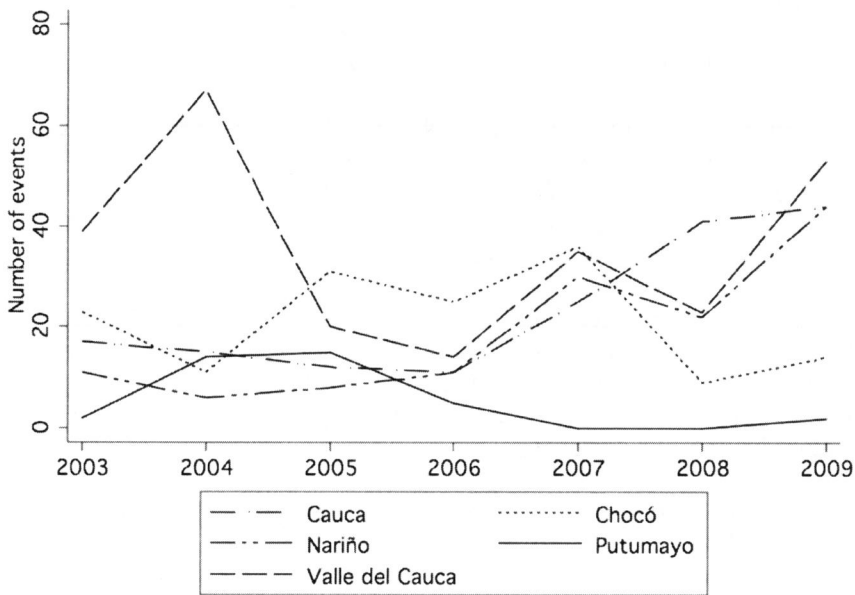
For the purpose of quantifying paramilitary violence, I created my own violence dataset for the 2003–9 period based on the information from the *Noche y Niebla* (NN) quarterly. My dataset lists violent acts registered in the territory of five administrative departments of the Colombian Pacific Coast (Cauca, Chocó, Nariño, Putumayo, Valle del Cauca) allegedly perpetrated by paramilitary groups. NN is published by the Centro de Investigación y Educación Popular (CINEP) and reports violence attributable to all participants in the Colombian civil war from 2001 to the present. CINEP gathers information from more than 20 daily local and national newspapers and from large-scale fieldwork, including interviews with human rights NGO members, local public ombudsmen, and Catholic priests (Restrepo et al. 2004, 403–4). The number of registered cases is massive, and each of them is described in extraordinary detail.

What's more, NN's data collection procedure most probably minimizes the visibility bias intrinsic to the data on organized crime violence. This type of data usually registers only those situations in which something goes seriously wrong between extralegal governance providers and those they "protected," overlooking inherent moderate-level violence (threats, intimidations, nonlethal injuries), which occurs continuously in turbulent private ordering environments (see Smith and Varese 2001). Since NN-registered denunciations are not really incriminating and cannot lead to legal prosecution, the quarterly has more chance to learn about violent incidents that would probably pass unobserved in official statistics. Researchers from the Centro de Recursos para el Análisis de Conflictos (CERAC) verified the quality of NN's data collection procedure and confirmed its compatibility with other data sources on conflict-related violence in Colombia (Restrepo et al. 2004, 406).

The dataset covers the period from the beginning of the DDR process until three years after the conclusion of its "DD" components (disarmament and demobilization). It coincides with the two terms of Álvaro Uribe's presidency, controlling for the fundamental policy turns. NN publications do not differentiate between pre- and postdemobilization paramilitary groups, which are sometimes interpreted as two separate phenomena. This is not a problem for the analysis, given that the ongoing debate about the nature of postdemobilization paramilitaries and their continuity with predemobilization groups has already documented profound links between the two types of organizations (CNRR 2007; ICG 2007). The crucial characteristic of this dataset is a disaggregation of municipal violence not only by its modality, but also by the nature of its perpetrator. This permits us to observe the changes in a single security milieu at the subregional level, as suggested by Humphreys and Weinstein (2009).

The Pacific Coast region was chosen for analysis because it offers an opportunity for interesting subregional comparisons. First, the trends in paramilitary violence during the period under study vary significantly across Pacific Coast municipalities. Figure 1 demonstrates the heterogeneity of violence dynamics at the departmental level. As we can see, the trends range from overall violence reduction (Chocó) to relative stability (Putumayo) and progressive escalation (Cauca, Nariño). Second, the Pacific Coast comprises some of the places with the most precarious

Figure 1. Paramilitary Violence: Department Trends on the Pacific Coast



Source: *Noche y Niebla* (CINEP), author's elaboration.

public infrastructure. The presence of such localities provides a chance to address the arguments of state weakness and its alleged impact on DDR failure.

Furthermore, in the period under study, the Pacific Coast hosted a diverse mix of organized violence actors. Apart from a strong insurgent presence, two of the biggest paramilitary groups not participating in the DDR program (the Rastrojos and the Machos) operated in the region between 2003 and 2009. The presence of all those peace “spoilers” pushed the state to launch a heavy military crackdown against some irregular armed groups in the region. In sum, the Pacific Coast offers considerable variation on the dependent variable and key explanatory ones.

EMPIRICS I: QUANTITATIVE EVIDENCE

The first empirical section will test statistically the main proposition of the article in order to see whether paramilitary violence actually increases in response to state antiparamilitary repression. Paramilitary violence is defined here as unilateral attack attributable to paramilitary groups against any type of human civilian target, including actions such as homicides, disappearances, arbitrary detainments, tortures, and sexual abuses.

The organized crime literature does not make any specific predictions about the modalities of organized crime violence most likely to occur in response to law

enforcement crackdown; therefore I code all violent events into one indicator. Dependent variable (DV) in all the models proposed in this section is an annual count of paramilitary unilateral attacks registered at the municipal level for the 2003–9 period. The DV's distribution is characterized both by an excessive number of zero counts and by an overdispersion.

A zero-inflated negative binomial (ZINB) model seems to be the most appropriate estimation technique for this kind of response variable (Cameron and Trivedi 1998). First, a standard ordinary least squares regression cannot be employed for count DV, since it may lead to negative predicted values (King 1988). More important, the ZINB model can account for the fact that zero observations in the response variable are generated in two different ways (Long 1997). On the one hand, there may be no paramilitary violence in municipality A at time t simply because no paramilitaries were there at t . On the other hand, there may be no paramilitary violence in municipality B at t because the relations between the local population and paramilitary groups remained good throughout a year and there was no significant breakdown in these relations that could get registered in NN data. In the case of municipality A, we should speak of a so-called certain zero observation, which has to be explained in a different way from a zero observation relative to municipality B.

The ZINB regression combines two separate models. In the first step, an inflation (logit) model is generated to predict whether a municipal observation falls into "certain zero" group or not. I use two instruments to single out "certain zero" cases at this stage of the analyses. The first one comes from the CERAC conflict dataset and measures paramilitary municipal presence on a binary scale, scoring 1 if any paramilitary group was present in a municipality during a year, and zero otherwise. I noticed that in the case of 59 municipal observations in which CERAC declares no paramilitary presence, NN data still report instances of paramilitary violence. For this reason, I added the second variable to the inflation model, which uses the cumulative score of the DV. The logic behind the inflation model goes as follows: a municipality with no paramilitary violence at time t is likely to be a "certain zero" case if there is no evidence of paramilitary presence in the municipality at t and if no previous paramilitary violence had been registered there from the beginning of the analyzed period until t .

In the second step, the ZINB regression generates a negative binomial model in order to estimate the intensity of paramilitary violence for those municipalities that are not predicted as "certain zero" cases. For this part of the ZINB model, I try three nested specifications. First, I use two explanatory variables that criminologically oriented studies usually associate with the intensity of organized violence in Colombia. Garzón (2008) suggests, for example, that most contemporary paramilitary violence represents within-paramilitary fighting, which intensified in the wake of the AUC's dissolution and the fragmentation of post-AUC organizations. Criminal research shows that violence begets violence in such fragmented extralegal governance milieus due to monopoly-building pressures (Gaviria 1998, 12) or simple retaliation dynamics (Morselli et al. 2008, 157).

To account for these escalation effects, model 1 includes a variable (*Escalation*) that captures year-to-year differences in the counts of municipal paramilitary attacks. If the escalation is at work here, the magnitude of these year-to-year differences should be positively correlated with the actual levels of DV. The econometric literature on crime in Colombia finds also that the levels of organized violence are strictly related to the quality of the criminal justice system (Gaviria 1998; Gaitán 2001; Sánchez et al. 2005). In order to see whether the relationship holds for paramilitary violence, I use a variable (*Arrests*) that reports the annual counts of paramilitaries arrested in each department of reference (source: National Police statistics). Given the lack of disaggregated police data, the variable could not be coded at the municipal level. Because of *Arrests*'s overdispersion, I include its logarithm in model 1. Although I expect that the variable has a negative effect on DV (in accordance with Howe et al. 2010), any significant result should be interpreted with caution, given the aggregation issues already discussed.

In order to account for conflict-related dynamics, model 2 adds three new explanatory variables to the previous model's specification (all coded with the CERAC conflict dataset). The first one (*Repression*) measures state antiparamilitary repression on a binary scale. It scores 1 if there was any municipal-level clash between public forces and paramilitary groups during a year, and zero otherwise. I use the word *repression* rather than *confrontation* because in most cases it was a state antiparamilitary offensive that provoked these military clashes (Granada, Restrepo, and Vargas 2009, 28). In line with my theoretical argument, I hypothesize that the *Repression* variable has a strong positive effect on DV.

Model 2 introduces another two conflict-related dummy variables that account for paramilitaries' interactions with their biggest extralegal governance competitors—insurgent groups. The first dummy (*Guerrilla_clashes*) captures the incidence of actual guerrilla-paramilitary competition, indicating whether or not any municipal-level clash between insurgent and paramilitary factions occurred during a year. The second dummy variable (*Guerrilla_presence*) reports guerrillas' municipal presence, scoring 1 in the case of any insurgent activity registered at the municipal level during a year, and zero otherwise. Although many studies reject the claim about the counterinsurgency character of contemporary paramilitarism, they still admit that criminal competition between guerrillas and paramilitary groups may be the reason for persistently high levels of organized violence in some parts of the Pacific Coast (Vásques and Vargas 2011; Barreto Henriques 2009, 554–58). I expect, therefore, that both *Guerrilla_clashes* and *Guerrilla_presence* will have a positive effect on DV.

One caveat needs to be made at this point. Any relationship between DV and conflict-related variables can technically work in both directions—with paramilitary violence being either the cause or the consequence of state repressive actions or insurgents' activities. If the direction of causality is actually uncertain here, my models, as they stand, risk ending up with inconclusive results. Carey (2006, 7) suggests that the problem can be overcome by lagging all endogenous explanatory variables included in the models in order to discard the possibility of reversed causality within captured correlations. In practice, this solution requires me to regress para-

military violence at time t on state repression and insurgents' competition proxies at $t-1$. I extend this lag structure to the *Arrests* variable, given its equally possible endogeneity.

Model 3 keeps all the predictors from model 2, adding three time-invariant controls to account for baseline differences in the levels of paramilitary violence attributable to municipality-specific characteristics. The first variable (*NBI*) controls for poverty level using the percentage of municipal population living with basic needs unsatisfied (source: DANE). Although poverty usually increases returns from criminal activity (because of lower opportunity costs; see Dude and Vargas 2013), I do not think it correlates positively with municipal paramilitary violence. Local poverty means less economic exchange and thus may actually discourage paramilitary type of governance, which usually targets areas with multiple economic transactions and larger "taxation" opportunities (see Bandiera 2003). For this reason I expect *NBI* to have a negative effect on DV.

The second control variable (*ICOFIS*) reports an institutional coverage index that uses 16 instruments to capture the quality of public institutions at the municipal level (source: DNP). The index is measured on a continuous scale scoring between zero and 1, with lower scores indicating worse institutional coverage. *ICOFIS* can be interpreted as a static proxy of state capacity, and as such I expect that it has a negative effect on DV (see Howe et al. 2010). The last variable (*Resguardo*) controls for the presence of indigenous collective territories (*resguardos*), scoring 1 if there is any *resguardo* within municipal borders and zero otherwise (source: MAVDT). Indigenous communities are famous for their self-governance traditions, such as the maintenance of their own self-defense units (*Verdad Abierta* 2012a) and the management of independent justice (Reyes 2014). As a result, they remain in highly conflictual relations with any external governance providers (Barreto Henriques 2009), and therefore their collective presence should have a positive effect on paramilitary violence.

Apart from these variables, all models include the log of population's size (*Population*) as a semiexposure variable (source: DANE), along with year dummies, which control for regional conflict dynamics characterized by occasional large-scale events that affect extralegal governance on the entire Pacific Coast. Such events comprise three waves of collective demobilizations, coca eradication operations, international investments, the arrival of new extralegal governance actors, and the signing and breaking of alliances among irregular armed groups operating in the region.

Since my data were gathered both between panels and across time, I cluster standard errors at the municipal level in order to correct for autocorrelations within panels. The number of observations, mean, and standard deviation for each variable can be consulted in table 1. Unfortunately, the variables coded on the basis of CERAC information are missing a lot of data, and when I included them in the models, many municipal observations were dropped from regression analyses. To understand the size and direction of a possible bias, table 1 reports DV's separate descriptive statistics for all municipal observations and for the subsample effectively used in the analyses with CERAC variables. Not surprisingly, the observations with missing data refer to very few municipal panels that experienced minimal levels of

Table 1. Descriptive Statistics for Variables in Models 1–3

Variable	Observations	Mean	Standard deviation	Source
Escalation	1,092	.08	1.98	<i>Noche y Niebla</i> (CINEP)
Arrests	1,274	41.45	40.50	National Police
Repression	746	.181	.385	CERAC, v.5.2
Guerrilla_clashes	746	.177	.382	CERAC, v.5.2
Guerrilla_presence	746	.714	.452	CERAC, v.5.2
NBI	1,274	.495	.235	DANE, population census 2005
ICOFIS	1,169	.289	.141	DNP, 1999
Resguardo	1,274	.187	.390	MAVDT, indigenous census 2005
Population (2005)	1,274	43,984	164,398	DANE, population census 2005
Dependent variable	1,274	.51	1.95	<i>Noche y Niebla</i> (CINEP)
Dependent variable (analyzed sample)	746	.82	2.47	<i>Noche y Niebla</i> (CINEP)

paramilitary violence throughout the entire period under study (out of 528 observations only 24 differed from zero). Their exclusion from the analyses should not bear on the results, since they most probably represent the municipalities that did not host any organized violence actors between 2003 and 2009.

Table 2 reports the results for negative binomial part of all the three ZINB models.² Consistent with expectations, I find strong evidence that the intensity of paramilitary violence is driven by the escalation dynamics. The *Escalation* variable is highly significant and positive across all models. This finding lends support to the arguments claiming that within-paramilitary fighting explains the huge volumes of paramilitary violence in some parts of the country since AUC's dissolution in 2003 (Vásquez and Vargas 2011). Nevertheless, escalation alone provides only a partial explanation for the heterogeneity of observed violence trends. By using the Akaike information criterion (AIC), we can see that the inclusion of additional variables in the model significantly improves its estimation results.³ Respective AIC scores tell us that model 1 is 8.99×10^{-37} times as probable as model 2 to minimize the (estimated) information loss and 1.01×10^{-43} times as probable as model 3.

What is new that we learn about paramilitary violence dynamics from the latter two models? Most important, they demonstrate that the intensity of paramilitary violence increases in response to state antiparamilitary repression. Other things equal, models 2 and 3 predict, respectively, 113 percent and 85 percent more paramilitary violence per year for the municipalities with recent prior instances of antiparamilitary crackdown, compared to the ones that experienced no crackdown at the same time. The magnitude and significance of this effect seem big enough to attract policymakers' attention.

Table 2. Intensity of Municipal Paramilitary Violence on the Pacific Coast, 2003–2009 (ZINB models)

Dependent Variable: Paramilitary violence _{it} (number of events in a municipality per year)			
	Model 1	Model 2	Model 3
Escalation	.110** (.052)	.104** (.046)	.095** (.039)
Arrests (log) _{t-1}	-.001 (.021)	-.008 (0.020)	-.026 (.022)
Repression _{t-1}		.757*** (.226)	.617*** (.186)
Guerrilla_clashes _{t-1}		.010 (.200)	.050 (.193)
Guerrilla_presence		.343 (.219)	.240 (.177)
NBI			.795 (.665)
ICOFIS			-.250 (1.405)
Resguardo			.4366 (.283)
Population (log)	.541*** (.130)	.379*** (.127)	.528*** (.186)
Constant	-5.766*** (1.362)	-4.165*** (1.389)	-6.072*** (1.716)
N	644	492	477
Wald χ^2	181.11***	219.13***	295.88***
Degrees of freedom	8	11	14
AIC	1,126	960	928

* $p < .10$, ** $p < .05$, *** $p < .01$.

Notes: Coefficients reported only from the negative binomial part of the zero-inflated negative binomial (ZINB) models. Robust standard errors clustered on municipalities (in parentheses). Year fixed effects not reported.

One of the most unexpected results of the present analyses is the insignificance of the *Guerrilla_clashes* variable. Yet not finding a relationship is not equal to finding that this relationship does not exist. For example, the models might not have captured the effect of guerrilla-paramilitary competition because they use a binary competition proxy instead of the actual counts of registered guerrilla-paramilitary clashes (unfortunately not available at the municipal level in the CERAC dataset).⁴ More probably, though, the insignificance of *Guerrilla_clashes* reflects the fact that the variable has only a short-term effect on paramilitary violence not captured by a

one-year lag structure applied to the present analyses. Controlling for direct guerrilla-paramilitary competition, I find that paramilitary violence increases, *ceteris paribus*, with insurgents' municipal presence on average by 27 to 41 percent annually (models 3 and 2, respectively). These results, however, are not significant at the conventional .10 level (p -values equal to .175 and .117 for models 3 and 2, respectively), and therefore remain inconclusive.

In line with the arguments that describe indigenous groups as paramilitaries' direct enemies (see Barreto Henriques 2009), model 3 reports a positive relationship between indigenous collective presence (*Resguardo*) and paramilitary violence. Other things equal, the municipalities with *resguardo* within their administrative borders are predicted to experience, on average, 44 percent more paramilitary violence per year than the municipalities with no indigenous collective territory. Having said that, the variable's coefficient is not significant at the conventional .10 level (p -value equal to .196), which puts a big caveat on the finding. What is more, model 3 yields even less significant coefficients for another two time-invariant controls (*ICOFIS* and *NBI*). In short, it seems that municipality-specific characteristics have no direct effect on the baseline differences in the experience of paramilitary violence at the subregional level of the Pacific Coast.

EMPIRICS II: QUALITATIVE EVIDENCE

The quantitative analyses largely support the argument of state repression's positive effect on paramilitary violence, but they do not offer many insights into the mechanisms that drive this relationship. The present section attempts to fill this gap by examining two hypotheses laid out in the theoretical section. I argue that there were two specific outcomes of state repressive actions that intensified paramilitary violence on the Pacific Coast.

First, I believe that the state antiparamilitary crackdown triggered resource substitution processes in which paramilitaries resorted to violence in order to compensate for losses in other crucial resources, such as reputation, advertising, and intelligence (hypothesis 1). Second, I hypothesize that crackdown-related shocks provoked paramilitaries' organizational adaptations, which reinforced their predatory tendencies and ultimately contributed to the escalation of paramilitary violence (hypothesis 2). To address these hypotheses, I use qualitative sources, including NN's descriptions of reported violence (e.g., testimonies from victims, law enforcement authorities, or presumed perpetrators), official and NGO reports, the Colombian press, and secondary academic literature.

One problem with this data is an unbalanced focus on the instances of DDR subregional failures and scarce attention to the municipalities that actually experienced security improvements. While I find some evidence to support each of the two hypotheses, given potential visibility bias, the discussion here cannot be fully conclusive. Instead of actually testing the hypotheses, we can only establish their plausibility, indicating the issues that should receive greater attention in future research.

Hypothesis 1: Resource Substitution

There is a lot of evidence that after the beginning of the antiparamilitary crackdown on the Pacific Coast the most downtrodden groups were fragmented into a myriad of small paramilitary organizations (Granada, Restrepo, and Tobón 2009, 470; Garzón 2008). Their fragmentation was followed by almost immediate rebranding of the surviving factions, which undermined paramilitaries' local recognition and affected their advertising capacities (HRW 2010, 88). Newly rebranded groups moved around territories organizing community meetings, where they introduced themselves to local residents and "advertised" their extralegal governance services. "They've done two meetings with the community in Santa Cruz and say that they're Rastrojos. They set schedules" (HRW 2010, 85).

Paramilitary newcomers often resorted to violence as the most efficient way of advertising. It allowed them to demonstrate their own "usefulness" to the community and at the same time to warn those who were unwilling to accept their authority. "We kill useless ones, thieves, violators, drunkards, all of this, you understand? This is a part of the organization. But we do this for example when we reach a neighborhood or a town of many thieves, marihuana addicts" (Ex-paramilitary soldier, quoted in Medina Arbeláez 2009, 115).

The paramilitaries' recognition problems on the Pacific Coast were inevitably linked to the fact that very few groups in the region maintained contingent territorial control (see Vicepresidencia de la República 2006, 46). Indeed, most of them avoided areas with good institutional coverage, operating exclusively "among the populations where one can arrive only via rivers or roads in terrible condition" (*Verdad Abierta* 2011). In more developed areas, they did not wear uniforms and stayed dispersed among civilians' houses (HRW 2010, 75, 83; Diócesis de Tumaco 2011, 50).

Apart from advertising difficulties, discontinuous territorial presence affected paramilitaries' monitoring capacities and aggravated their free-riding problem (e.g., NN, Nariño, 15.01.2009). Even the most resourceful groups preferred to operate in the very restricted areas of poor neighborhoods in port towns and other drug-trafficking hubs (ISC 2014). In those localities they could more easily control civilians' movements, victimizing even those who simply walked between neighboring parts of town (NN, Nariño, 24.03.2012; 14.03.2012). Paramilitaries chose to use partly indiscriminate violence because they lacked more efficient tools to distinguish between collaborative and defective behavior of their "protégés." A person who visits a neighboring part of town may actually be an informer for the rivals, but more probably the person's movements have nothing to do with criminal activities. If the latter is true, paramilitaries incur unnecessary (but still unavoidable) costs by punishing him.

Reputation for violence was the third crackdown-affected resource for which Pacific Coast paramilitaries substituted actual violence. Let us consider the following example: a paramilitary rank-and-file soldier recently released from prison wants to take revenge on a random woman (possibly a lawyer) traveling on the same bus.

The threatened woman responds to his threats calmly, “*Señor*, I am sick, let me go. I can’t talk, put down these things [gun].” Then the attacker shouts that he is an *Urabeño* (member of a Pacific Coast paramilitary group), but the woman continues to act calmly and alights from the bus where she originally planned (NN, Cauca, 20.12.2012).

We can clearly see that in this case, paramilitary membership did not suffice to effectively intimidate the woman. She decided to test the credibility of her aggressor’s threats because she strongly doubted his coercive capabilities. Testing the paramilitaries’ reputation for violence has not been uncommon on the Pacific Coast since 2003. In Chocó, paramilitaries lamented that people were refusing them any help, medicine included (NN, Chocó, 04.05.2004). Elsewhere, a taxi driver declined to give a ride to a small group of paramilitary soldiers (NN, Nariño, 30.01.2009). Most of these situations ended in bloodshed, and the available evidence lends support to the hypothesis that paramilitaries reacted violently to reaffirm their local authority.

Hypothesis 2: Predatory Turn

Another argument identifying the links between state crackdown and increased paramilitary violence stresses the importance of organizational adaptations within those paramilitary groups that underwent heavy repressive action. This process can be illustrated with an example of the Rastrojos, a paramilitary group that, according to nongovernmental sources, at least toward the end of analyzed period operated in the majority of Pacific Coast municipalities with the worst security record.⁵

The Rastrojos took their name from the armed wing of the Norte del Valle drug cartel, which transformed itself into a paramilitary organization in the early twenty-first century. After 2005, the group hired a significant portion of demobilized ex-AUC members, who took control of its command structure (Vicepresidencia de la República 2006, 27–28). Since the beginning of the state antiparamilitary crackdown, the Rastrojos have experienced numerous changes in their hierarchy as a result of imprisonment and extradition of the group’s key leaders (e.g., Juan Carlos Calle, alias “Armando,” and Diego Pérez Henao, alias “Rastrojo”; see *Verdad Abierta* 2012b; ISC 2014). The persistent law enforcement actions and the growing risks of organizational centralization led the Rastrojos to introduce more horizontality to their organization, along with heavier reliance on midlevel commanders (ISC 2014). Once the adaptations were applied, the Rastrojos’ loosely connected factions started to operate semi-independently, with minimum cooperation among themselves. Not surprisingly, this created intraorganizational conflict and the continuous dilemma of decentralized predation.

Following a disarticulation of the command nucleus—with imprisonment or death of most important leaders—[the Rastrojos’] structures ... entered into internal competition, falling into disputes about the markets, territorial domination, trafficking corridors, and the leadership of the remaining structures. (Vicepresidencia de la República 2006, 17)

The persistent repression and organizational instability affected the Rastrojos' relations with their protégés. We know that state crackdown dealt a serious blow to group's revenues: "Testimonies indicate that they had gone for more than four months without pay" (Garzón 2008, 41). These financial hardships forced the Rastrojos to look for alternative revenue sources, which included an intensified resort to predatory and extortive practices. While it seems clear that group members recognized the growing risk of prosecution, it should not surprise us that they became more concerned about immediate rather than future rewards (Vicepresidencia de la República 2006, 19).

As a result, from 2004 on, the Rastrojos started to impose their governance in a clearly extortive manner, approaching easy-to-monitor individuals instead of those who might effectively need the group's services. For example, "they ask for the *vacuna* [tax] and if there are cattle or a chicken, they take it.... It's very high ... in a very poor area" (HRW 2010, 87). Their most frequent demands included payments in cheap electronic devices (television set, radio, mobile phone), basic food products (flour, bread, milk, vegetables), and medicine (see NN, Cauca, 10.02.2007, 27.11.2010; Chocó, 04.05.2004). These extortions were not exchanged with any real services and therefore required substantial doses of coercion on the Rastrojos' part. One paramilitary soldier tried to justify these predatory actions by explaining that "things are hard here, and if one doesn't defend himself, he dies" (NN, Cauca, 20.12.2012).

CONCLUDING REMARKS

This article has attempted to account for the heterogeneous dynamics of paramilitary violence on the Colombian Pacific Coast between 2003 and 2009. Empirical data clearly show that the puzzle of why some Colombian subregions benefited from DDR-related "deparamilitarization" of conflict more than others can hardly be explained with the argument of state weakness. In fact, there is no evidence that paramilitary violence diminished with improved policing or better institutional coverage, as implied by Howe et al.'s argument (2010). Conversely, this article has demonstrated quantitatively that the presence of state antiparamilitary repression increased the intensity of municipal paramilitary violence by at least 85 percent each year. The qualitative analyses further suggest that state crackdown fueled paramilitary violence on the Pacific Coast by triggering resource substitution processes and creating predatory incentives among regional paramilitary groups. Generally speaking, I believe that the study shows that the concept of state capacity needs to be disaggregated in order to understand which weaknesses and which strengths may contribute to the perpetuation or reduction of insecurity. These findings have a few important implications.

First of all, this research suggests that any attempts to fix structural forms of state weakness with emergency instruments are unlikely to bring immediate security dividends. A resident of one Pacific Coast municipality recalls,

Before the Rastrojos, we had NG [New Generation]. The army attacked NG about a year ago.... The army stayed three weeks. They left, and a few days later the Rastrojos entered Santa Rosa and Santa Cruz. The NG did too, but as Black Eagles.... The Rastrojos do checkpoints in Santa Cruz.... The Black Eagles and Rastrojos are fighting over territory. (HRW 2010, 85).⁶

The quotation illustrates that the military interventions on the Pacific Coast from 2003 to 2009 could not establish everyday order in the long run because they could not prevent the arrival of new extralegal governance providers or the retreats of previously defeated ones.

In short, antiparamilitary repression did not eradicate the roots of extralegal governance in the region but did manage to destroy or weaken its major providers. The local demand for paramilitary governance on the Pacific Coast has not been eliminated with the defeat of some paramilitary groups, and Nussio argues that local community members still perceive paramilitaries as those “who provide private security services ... who can help in case of some inconveniences, some problems” (2009, 227).

Second, while I believe that these findings are not necessarily limited to the Pacific Coast case, they cannot be generalized to every Colombian region. One of the fundamental characteristics of the Pacific Coast crackdown was its relative impartiality, which meant that all paramilitary groups in the region were equally subject to state repressive actions. Although some sources observed that public forces occasionally allied themselves with one paramilitary faction against another (e.g., NN, Nariño, 03.02.2012; HRW 2010, 83), there is no evidence that these alliances favored any paramilitary actor in a persistent and systematic fashion. Surprisingly, this impartiality cannot be taken for granted in other Colombian regions. There is some evidence that in the Eastern Plains, for instance, law enforcement authorities intentionally spared two paramilitary groups, targeting almost exclusively their paramilitary rivals (CITP 2009; González 2007). Given the partisanship of this intervention, I imagine that the positive relationship between state crackdown and paramilitary violence may not hold for the Eastern Plains (see Morselli et al. 2008, 162).

This analysis also offers important policy implications for the ongoing peace process with the largest Colombian guerrilla group, the Fuerzas Armadas Revolucionarias de Colombia (FARC). This study suggests that the outcomes of insurgents’ forthcoming demobilization may largely depend on the state’s reaction to a potential rearmament of some FARC factions, an issue notably neglected in the existing forecasts (e.g., Nussio and Howe 2012). There remains one tempting question at the end of this work: did the Colombian state do well to launch a military crackdown against paramilitaries on the Pacific Coast? The intervention has had its high costs, but they seemed rather inevitable. Smith and Varese argue that

the level of violence observed by citizens actually increases precisely at the moment when the state is supplying better policing to the community.... Violence is an unavoidable consequence of fighting organized crime ... from a public policy perspective, these instances of violence are signs of success, rather than failure. (2001, 364–76)

This quotation reminds us that what looks like a failure from the perspective of a conflict resolution practitioner may be perceived as a success by an organized crime analyst.

NOTES

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1. Since 2006, official sources refer to paramilitary groups as *bandas criminales*. Academic sources prefer to call them neoparamilitaries (Granada, Restrepo, and Tobón 2009) or “new armed illegal groups” (ICG 2007).

2. The results of the inflation model are concordant with my expectations. The odds of being a “certain zero” observation are 3.2 to 3.9 (dependent on the model’s specification) for each municipality where no paramilitary presence could be confirmed at time t , and which experienced no paramilitary violence from the beginning of the analyzed period until t . Any increase (or discrete change) in the variables included in the inflation model (DV’s cumulative score and paramilitary presence dummy) has a highly significant negative effect on these odds.

3. For details on the AIC basis for model selection, see Burnham and Anderson (2002, 60–64, 302–5).

4. It should be noted, though, that the analogically measured *Repression* dummy yields highly significant results in all models.

5. To establish this fact I consulted yearly reports of municipal paramilitary presence (disaggregated by group) at <http://ediciones.indepaz.org.co>. Unfortunately they are available only from 2008 on.

6. NG and Black Eagles are the names of paramilitary groups operating on the Pacific Coast after 2006.

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